

the intent is to hang something at home in the hope that it will appreciate in value, but will that realisation actually filter down to your bank account? To know and gain from that, it's important to learn how the art world functions, and its pitfalls.

The first of which is that dreaded word: Fakes. There's an entire industry churning out fakes because margins are so huge, it would be a crime not to want to benefit from it. The art mafia feeds on those vulnerable to deals. Here's the caveat: There are no deals in the art world. The seller knows the value of the art, which is easily available online, so why should she settle for anything less than the maximum, distress sale or not? A deal in the art world is no deal at all—it's a mirage, and you've just been handed an expensive lemon.

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Somebody who can fake paintings can certainly fake authenticity certificates and provenances—official documents are desirable but often don't exist in the case of the masters—so don't be taken in by them. The 'Psst! I have a Souza' is the oldest con game in the industry. Not only do I receive scores of images every week from someone-who-knows-someone-who-has-something-to-sell, really bad fakes are now seemingly finding their way even from overseas to buyers in India who think 'foreign' at least is not suspect. It is.

Art as an investment is real, but remember, not all works by an artist command the heights you see as benchmarks in auctions. That validation comes with quality, rarity, and history. Most works by the same artist will command a lower premium (though artists go through trends in popularity), so you need to figure out your entry points and budgets and stick, within reason, to that.

Second, read...not just auction results but catalogues, books, monographs, and where possible, figure who's buying the works of a particular artist—whether a master or an emerging artist. Known collectors and museums are your green signal; simply follow in their footsteps.

Three, the size of your investment matters, so tailor it accordingly. If the kitty is large, you can opt for the

Clockwise from facing page: *The Red Girl* by MF Husain sold for a record ₹65 crore in 2026 at Pundole's in Mumbai; Husain's *Untitled (Gram Yatra)* oil-on-canvas mural sold for roughly ₹118.7 crore in 2025 at Christie's New York; Saffronart auctioned Akbar Padamsee's *Greek Landscape* for ₹19.9 crore in 2016

